
Dialect Leveling by Age Group: A Case Study of the Kyoto Dialect*

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From microdialects, which are defined by extremely narrow geographic areas, to macrodialects, which encompass broad regions, it is undeniable that dialects across the board are losing their distinctiveness – that is to say, they increasingly resemble standard Japanese. This tendency cannot be attributed to a single cause; rather, it arises from the interplay of many competing factors. If the emergence of dialects can be traced to natural causes – specifically, the limited interaction between regions due to geographical separation – or to artificial causes, as seen in the Edo period (1603–1868), when dialects were reinforced as tools for maintaining the shogunate-domain system, then today, scientific advancement has largely eliminated the former (natural) causes, and political changes have completely removed the rationale for the latter (artificial) ones. As a result, the forces that once maintained dialects have been reduced to virtually nothing. Conversely, today, numerous factors actively promote dialect leveling, including the rise of mass media (especially the spread of television, which exerts a strong visual and auditory influence), school education, and even more abstract forces such as admiration for the Tokyo dialect stemming from a centralist ideological framework. Given this significant movement, how are dialects actually changing in practice? While the view that standardization should be more pronounced among younger generations than among older ones is irrefutable on a theoretical level, this paper objectively assesses this reality by examining the Kyoto dialect by age group. The goal is to identify which parts of the dialect are most susceptible or most resistant to erosion, and to trace the process by which a single dialectal system undergoes change – especially in terms of the relationship between Kyotoites’ standard Japanese awareness and dialect leveling.

For example, in terms of vocabulary, the Kyoto dialect has *yotogi* as a counterpart to the standard Japanese word *otuya* ~ *otūya* お通夜 ‘funerary wake’. This study investigated the extent to which users of the former are aware of and have come to employ the latter standard Japanese term, and how their usage shifts depending on the communicative context. Participants were asked to imagine speaking with someone outside their family, especially someone they were meeting for the first time and who uses standard Japanese, and the relationship between changes in language use and awareness of standard Japanese was examined. To illustrate: in conversations among family members, Informant A (age 67) and his son Informant B (age 42) use *yotogi*. Informant A sees *otuya* as a separate word (although he is aware of its existence), while Informant B uses *otuya* when speaking with outsiders or in formal situations. Meanwhile,

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Informant B's son, Informant C (age 17), uses *otuya* in all contexts, regardless of the setting. This example shows that while dialects may appear to exhibit stark generational divides in everyday language use, when analyzed in terms of language awareness and context of use, these divides often reveal themselves to be more gradual inclines than sharp breaks. In this study, I would also like to take these aspects into consideration.

The Kyoto dialect has traditionally exhibited numerous phonological, grammatical, and lexical differences and contrasting features in comparison with standard Japanese, which is itself based on the Tokyo dialect. However, in recent years, it has become increasingly fluid, showing variation marked by tendencies toward standard Japanese across all linguistic domains. That said, close observation reveals that this variation is not merely arbitrary but follows identifiable patterns. The National Institute for Japanese Language and Linguistics¹ once studied this kind of issue, investigating language use across three generations of families in Hokkaido to observe the process of dialect leveling. However, the problem of standard language use in Hokkaido differs fundamentally from what I aim to describe here in relation to the Kyoto dialect. In the Hokkaido case, people speaking a range of disparate dialects migrated to a region that, linguistically speaking, was almost a blank slate – lacking any dominant prior language and adopted a “common language” as a kind of linguistic least common denominator. In contrast, the situation of the Kyoto dialect concerns the transformation of an existing, long-standing language (dialect) through all kinds of assimilative forces; in other words, what is at issue here is a fundamental change occurring from the base of a single dialect. In this study, I have intentionally avoided extreme cases (i.e., those belonging to a narrowly-defined Kyoto dialect) and instead interpreted the Kyoto dialect more broadly as that which stands in contrast to standard Japanese (what we could call the Kinki region dialect). The data has been classified by accent, phonology, usage, and vocabulary, and the state of dialect leveling is presented through charts, divided into three different contexts of use (to be explained below).

Table: Participants by age

Age Group	No. of Persons
10–19	20
20–29	80
30–39	40
40–49	40
50–59	30
60–69	20
70 and over	20
special group	50

1 Kokuritsu Kokugo Kenkyūjo (国立国語研究所). 1965. *Kyōtsūgoka no katei* (共通語化の過程) [The process of standardization]. Shūei Shuppan (秀英出版); Satō, Makoto (佐藤誠). 1962. *Dantai ijū buraku to sono gengo no sedai-teki hen'yō* (団体移住部落とその言語の世代的変容) [Generational change in the language of communities that relocated en masse]. *Jinrui kagaku* (人類科学) 14, 6–21; Ushiyama, Hatsuo (牛山初男). 1969. *Nagano-ken Suwa chihō hōgen no kyōtsūgoka ni tsuite* (長野県諏訪地方方言の共通語化について) [On the Standardization of the Suwa dialect of Nagano Prefecture]. In *Tōzai hōgen no kyōkai* (東西方言の境界) [Boundaries between Eastern and Western dialects] Shinkyō Insatsu (信教印刷), 60–96. Shinkyō (信教).

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This study's research method was as follows.

Participants

This survey of approximately 250 men was conducted from June 1967 to August 1969. For participants aged 29 and under, eligibility was limited to those who had never lived outside of the Kinki region (defined as including Ishikawa and Fukui prefectures) for more than three consecutive months. For those aged 30 and above, the condition was relaxed to allow for those who had not lived outside of the region for more than one year (excluding time spent in military service). These conditions were adopted in order to select individuals who belonged to groups considered most conservatively positioned with regard to dialect leveling – that is, those situated at the margins of the standardization process and thus least affected by it. The study excluded people who graduated from secondary schools (*chūgakkō* 中学校), vocational colleges (*senmon gakkō* 専門学校) or higher-level institutions in prewar times and from universities in postwar times, as well as those whose professions were in education, law, or civil service. The language of such individuals is often shaped by a strong normative awareness due to external factors and thus it is difficult to consider them alongside other speakers in the same category when it comes to dialect leveling. However, for the purposes of comparison, I also conducted a separate survey of approximately fifty individuals born in Kyoto who did not meet the above criteria. These individuals – aged 30 to 75 – are presented here as a “special group”.²

To select survey participants, I prioritized vertical rather than horizontal social relationships – that is, families over school or workplace associations – because the latter are more susceptible to group influence, making it difficult to obtain averages. Therefore, most participants were recruited through introductions provided by the Ukyō 右京, Kamigyō 上京, and Kita 北 ward offices, which provided introductions to families that included elderly men over the age of 60. When additional participants were needed, primarily referrals were provided by municipal cooperation committee members (*shisei kyōryoku iin* 市政協力委員) in Kita and Kamigyō wards. For supplementary surveys, I received support from a number of institutions and organizations, including Motomachi 元町 and Shichiku 紫竹 elementary schools, Asahigaoka 旭ヶ丘 and Kinugasa 衣笠 junior high schools, Murasakino 紫野 High School (all city public schools in Kita Ward); Notre Dame Elementary School and Doshisha High School (both in Sakyō 左京 Ward); the Hirano Youth Association (Hirano Chiku Seinendan 平野地区青年団), the Shinmachi Prosperity Association (Shinmachi Kōeikai 新町繁栄会), the Miyoshi Association (Miyoshikai みよし会), the Shichiku 紫竹 Lions Club, and the Yasuhara Group (Yasuhara Gumi 安原組).

Research Methodology

In homes, data were primarily gathered by recording family conversations. Specifically, the family's oldest member was first asked to recount childhood memories to initiate the conversation, after which the rest of the family was encouraged to engage in a free conversation, which

² “Special group”: fifty Kyoto-born residents aged 30–75, no restrictions on occupation or outside-Kyoto residence, educational level at least pre-war secondary school. Occupations include teacher (elementary to university), physician, bank employee, civil servant, police officer, shop owner, lawyer, and unemployed.

was then recorded. In principle, the researcher was not present during this recording. This was done because the presence of a third party tends to shift speakers away from using dialect, thereby making it difficult to capture their everyday speech with accuracy.

In addition to these recordings, a supplementary questionnaire format, also employed by the National Institute for Japanese Language and Linguistics during the compilation of the *Nihon gengo chizu* 日本言語地図 ‘Linguistic atlas of Japan’ was used. For vocabulary items, participants were asked to name images or photographs. In cases where this method proved difficult (e.g., with abstract nouns), elicitation questions were used. The questions were posed in dialect by Tamura Ichirō 田村一郎 (age 70, from Murasakino, Kita Ward, former farmer). For example, when attempting to elicit the dialectal counterpart to the standard Japanese word *ikura* イクラ ‘how much’, that is, *nanbo* ナンボ, the question was asked, *Mise de suguki iqpon koote, sono ne tazuneharu toki donai iawaharimasu ka* 店ですぐき一本買うて、その値尋ねはるときどないいわはりますか ‘At a store, when you buy a pickled *suguki* turnip, what do you say when you ask the price?’. If this approach still did not yield the expected response, the researcher would fall back on directly asking, “Do you ever use the expression ...?” This fallback was necessary in approximately one quarter of the cases. However, when the results of these responses conflicted with those obtained from the recordings, the latter were given priority.

Survey Items

Survey items can be grouped into three broad categories: phonology, usage, and vocabulary. However, within the category of phonology, pitch accent was treated as a separate item due to its distinctive nature, making for a total of four categories. Where items were interrelated, they were classified according to whether they reflected general or item-specific (lexical) changes. For example, cases where the sounds *m* and *b* were switched in specific lexical items were classified under vocabulary.

Pitch Accent

Pitch accent was surveyed for nouns up to three moras³ in length. The table below presents only disyllabic nouns due to space constraints, but examples from other parts of speech were also referenced during interpretation. Note that for *uta+ga* (HL(L): H = high, L = low; standard Japanese: LH(L); ‘song+NOM’), a Class II noun, and *yama+ni* (HH(L); standard Japanese: LH(L); ‘mountain+DAT’), a Class III noun, no distinction was made since both have followed the same pattern of change in recent years. On average, about five words were surveyed per accent Class,⁴ and examples collected from free conversation were also taken into account during interpretation.

The table below shows the state of dialect leveling by age group. Before turning to it, I will explain the terminology used.

3 Translator’s note: For consistency, “mora” is used throughout this translation, even though the author uses that term and “syllable” interchangeably.

4 The twenty words surveyed with every participant were: (1) *ume* 梅, *kao* 顔, *sake* 酒, *take* 竹, *niwa* 庭, (2, 3) *kura* 倉, *oto* 音, *yama* 山, *uma* 馬, *kutu* 靴, (4) *umi* 海, *tane* 種, *hari* 針, *matu* 松, *hune* 舟, (5) *koe* 声, *ido* 井戸, *mado* 窓, *tatibana* 橘, *saru* 猿.

Awareness of Standard Japanese

This measure does not indicate the percentage of participants who actually used standard Japanese pitch accent. Rather, it refers to their ability to recognize it. For example, if a person used the accent pattern *take+ga* (high-high-high; ‘bamboo+NOM’) and was then asked, “What is the standard (Tokyo dialect) pitch accent for that word?”, and responded with *take+ga* (low-high-high), then that individual was considered to have awareness of the standard Japanese pitch accent for that word. If the participant could not answer, they were asked to read a short passage prepared in advance. According to this method, the data show that those capable of recognizing standard pitch accents were: 20% (4 out of 20) of people between 10 and 19 years old, 20% (16 out of 80) in their 20s, 10% (4 out of 40) in their 30s, and 0% in age groups above that.

Status of Dialect Leveling in Pitch Accents (unit: percentage)

Type	Context	10s	20s	30s	40s	50s	60s	70+	Special
Class I (<i>take</i>)	Awareness of Standard Japanese	20	20	10	0	0	0	0	66
	Public Conversation	15	15	10	0	0	0	0	40
	Family Conversation	10	10	0	0	0	0	0	8
Class II (<i>yama</i>)	Awareness of Standard Japanese	75	70	68	40	20	10	5	90
	Public Conversation	30	50	45	13	5	0	0	80
	Family Conversation	15	15	15	7	3	0	0	40
Class IV (<i>matu</i>)	Awareness of Standard Japanese	65	60	50	25	16	10	5	90
	Public Conversation	20	45	35	10	4	0	0	82
	Family Conversation	1	10	10	5	0	0	0	48
Class V (<i>kome</i>)	Awareness of Standard Japanese	80	70	60	37	20	15	10	94
	Public Conversation	25	45	45	10	5	0	0	85
	Family Conversation	10	10	8	3	0	0	0	51

It should be noted that the chart does not reflect the average across all surveyed words. Rather, for Class I nouns, for example, only the data for *take* were used. While this approach results in some variation depending on the word (described below), it does not affect the overall trend and was adopted due to issues with the method of calculating averages.

Public Conversation

This category involved formal settings, such as speeches or conversations with third-party interlocutors. “Public conversation”, then, is used here in contrast to “private group” conversations centered on family. This is because dialect use tends to be most suppressed in such formal situations, and there is a strong tendency to attempt to use standard Japanese.

To simulate this kind of situation, students from Tokyo were enlisted as interlocutors and engaged participants in conversation. The changes in language use (i.e., the degree of dialect leveling) observed in their responses were recorded by the author, who was present and took notes for statistical analysis. This particular survey was conducted between 1966 and 1968 and included a total of 215 participants.

Family Conversation

This refers to the language used in household conversation where no third party is present – in other words, everyday language. Here, I indicate the percentage of people who use the standard pitch accent for *take+ga* (low-high-high) in family conversation. This category offers a direct measure of the current state of dialect leveling. However, even within this context, it should not be assumed that speakers use standard pitch accent consistently. In fact, it was often the case that the same person used both the dialectal and standard accent patterns for the same word. It is difficult to determine whether this is done consciously, given the nature of the conversational context. However, this variation cannot simply be categorized as pitch accent ambiguity;⁵ rather, it likely represents a transitional phase in the process of dialect leveling.

From the results in the chart, the following points can be drawn:

- (1) Except for Class I nouns, there is little variation in the data.
- (2) Overall, dialect leveling in family conversation is extremely limited, with the 30s age group marking a turning point.
- (3) Awareness of standard Japanese for Class I nouns is especially low.

Although points (1) and (3) differ in phrasing, their meaning is the same. That is, awareness of standard Japanese for Class I nouns is significantly lower than for other classes, most likely because they lack a mora-to-mora pitch change, making them a special category when viewed from standard Japanese. People probably have a strong sense that “standard pitch accents are the reverse of Kyoto pitch accents”, which, in the context of flat, high accent of Class I nouns (e.g., *kao* 顔 ‘face’, *take* 竹, *sake* 酒 ‘alcohol’, *niwa* 庭 ‘garden’) that do not clearly have contrasting standard Japanese counterparts – unlike, for example, the Class III *yama+ni* (HH(L) vs. LH(L): H = high, L = low) or Class IV *umi+ga* (‘ocean+NOM’; LH(H) vs. HL(L)) and Class V *koe+ga* (‘voice+NOM’; LH(L) vs. HL(L)) – makes grasping standard pitch accent difficult. The same difficulty applies to surveyed Class I nouns – *take*, *kao*, *sake*, and *niwa* – as well as those collected from free conversation, such as *kaki* 柿 ‘persimmon’, *kaze* 風 ‘wind’, *hana* 鼻 ‘nose’, *tori* 鳥 ‘bird’, and *hati* 蜂 ‘bee’. However, for *ume* 梅 ‘plum’/‘apricot’, *usi* 牛 ‘cow’, and so on, the standard pitch accent rate is approximately ten percent higher overall. This may be because these words begin with a nasal sound, which is less acoustically salient, and thus the initial pitch is more often interpreted as low. This finding is supported by the results for trisyllabic nouns – for instance, the Class I *miyako* ミヤコ (HHH(H); standard Japanese: LHH(H); ‘capital’) – where it was very hard

⁵ Surveying the following homonyms showed that, standard pitch accent aside, there was little confusion in the dialect pitch accent: *hana* (鼻 ‘nose’, 花 ‘flower’), *hasi* (端 ‘edge’, 橋 ‘bridge’, 箸 ‘chopsticks’), *kaki* (柿 ‘persimmon’, 牡蠣 ‘oyster’), and *awa* (泡 ‘bubble’, 粟 ‘millet’).

for people to distinguish it from the standard form. Similar results were found for trisyllabic verbs such as *ugoku* ウゴク (HHH; standard Japanese: LHL; ‘to move’). Taken together, these data confirm the hypothesis above. It is also undeniable that a certain ambiguity arises with this accent Class. Standard LH(H) and LHH(H), which correspond to Kyoto HH(H) and HHH(H), were difficult to distinguish clearly, even when speakers consciously reflected on their own pronunciation. For the “special group”, the majority who could not distinguish the standard Japanese accent answered that the accents were “the same”, and a few responded with comments like, “If it’s HH(H) in Kyoto dialect, then I guess it would be LL(L) in standard Japanese.” This confusion may be because the respondents are learning pitch accents, rather than picking them up by ear, which may be due to the influence of *standard Japanese* language education.

Looking at noun classes II through V, no significant variation was observed when analyzed by word. However, people did have a slightly overall higher awareness of Class V nouns. This is likely because when surveyed without the addition of particles their accent pattern (HF: F = falling) is markedly different from the standard Japanese accent, which makes them more easily recognizable as dialectal forms. As a result, these items exhibit relatively high rates in both awareness and public conversation usage. This is corroborated by the “special group” having a high recognition rate of 94% and a high public conversation dialect leveling rate of 85%. That is to say, in situations where one feels that the use of standard Japanese is either required or socially preferable, 85% of participants actually did use it, suggesting that for them, dialect leveling is very conscious. (Its conscious nature is why the Class I rate is comparatively low.) The inverse of this pattern is observed in the rate in family speech of those over age 40. The fact that standard forms were used in none or near none of cases among those in this age group suggests that, in such private settings, there is virtually no awareness of standard Japanese, resulting in the use of stable dialectal forms – and hence the numbers we see here.

As for point (2), pitch accent differs from vocabulary and grammar in that it is extremely difficult to consciously align with standard Japanese. Since it functions continuously across an utterance, using a standard pitch pattern for only one part of a sentence sounds unnatural; yet adopting a standard pattern for the entire sentence requires a high level of knowledge, which many speakers lack. Pitch accent, therefore – especially unlike vocabulary, which is discontinuous and less constrained – is relatively resistant to the effects of dialect leveling. As for the dividing line in the thirty-something age group, a hypothesis can be formulated if we take into account the percentage for standard Japanese usage in public conversation. (The chart shows the percentage of individuals who can not only recognize the standard Japanese accent but actually use it.)

Higher percentages in this chart indicate a greater degree of consciously adopted standard Japanese. According to the data, the highest percentages are found in the 20s and 30s age brackets. Even among individuals between 10 and 19 years old, we observe that working individuals demonstrate greater standard Japanese usage than junior high or elementary school students. Similarly, salaried workers exhibit higher usage compared to those engaged in agriculture or

commerce among those in their 20s or 30s. This is likely because after going out into society, the surrounding language promotes a move away from dialect use. In external-facing interactions, using the standard Japanese accent is strongly perceived as a kind of politeness. Thus, speakers are consciously choosing to use the standard form whenever they are able to distinguish it, attempting to eliminate the sense of inferiority stemming from dialect usage – a psychological response, so to speak. The prevalence of this pattern among people in their 30s demonstrates that dialect leveling for this age group is significantly more intentional than for those in their teens and 20s.

Age Group	Awareness
10s	44%
20s	70%
30s	78%
40s	34%
50s	25%
60s	0%
70 and over	0%
special group	84%

The high rate found in the “special group” can be explained in similar terms. In other words, the *ability to use* the standard accent has effectively become one of the unspoken qualifications for belonging to the educated class. That dialect leveling is strongly influenced by linguistic environment is evident when comparing data from different elementary schools: the private Notre Dame vs. the municipal Motomachi. In school settings, nearly half of the students at the former school used the standard accent, while fewer than one quarter of the students at the latter school did so. Moreover, this shift appears confined to the school environment: students revert to using dialectal pitch patterns at home, further indicating that environmental influence plays a critical role. In addition, the role of education in fostering awareness of standard Japanese must also be considered. Those in their 30s experienced the postwar education system. Those who were enrolled in elementary school in 1945 (the end of World War II) were 29 to 35 years old at the time of this study. In 1951, the Ministry of Education released the revised curriculum guidelines for the Japanese language (*Gakushū shidō yōryō kokugoka-hen* 学習指導要領国語科編),⁶ which newly established the framework for teaching the Standard language, and this was also the time when calls emerged for audiovisual education. These developments cannot be overlooked. While education is not the sole factor, it does appear to be an important one for two reasons. First, the situation in the special group. Second, the extreme difference between dialect leveling in family conversation and the level of standard Japanese awareness indicates that dialect leveling in that group is clearly conscious and norm-driven.

⁶ Koshimizu, Minoru (興水実). 1952. *Kokugo kyōiku genron* (国語教育原論) [Principles of national-language education]. Asakura Shoten (朝倉書店).

In short, concerning pitch accent, although there is a conscious tendency toward standardization (with the exclusion of some forms), this trend remains largely superficial. At a deeper level, the speakers' linguistic attitudes remain quite conservative.

Phonology

The narrowly defined Kyoto dialect exhibits several phonological features: a somewhat ambiguous distinction between long and short vowels;⁷ a strong tendency for *s* to switch with *h*; and occasional mixing among the *z*, *d*, and *r*. However, these phenomena vary considerably even within the Kyoto dialect itself, making them difficult to generalize. Moreover, before they can even be discussed with regard to dialect leveling, one must first compare them against broader definitions of the Kyoto dialect. For these reasons, they were excluded from this study. Likewise, velar nasal *g* (*gagyō bidakuon* が行鼻濁音) in medial and final position were excluded, since they do not stand in contrast to standard Japanese. That said, across Japan, this sound is in noticeable decline. The degree of decline varies sharply according to sociolinguistic variables such as age, gender, and educational background, and is further complicated by the presence of normative awareness. For example, a 1968 survey of fifth-grade students at a number of elementary schools in Kyoto (30 students per school; 180 students total)⁸ revealed dramatic variation by school: in School A, over 90% of students used velar nasal *g*, whereas in School B, fewer than 30% did so. Since these schools are adjacent, differences in residential or family background cannot explain the variation. Upon closer investigation, the cause was found to be School A's instruction in *Standard language* pronunciation during music education.

This finding suggests that velar nasal *g* is in steep decline in Kyoto as a whole. Another feature of standard Japanese is the devoicing of vowels in medial and final position.⁹ However, I was not able to provide data on this because individual awareness of this phenomenon varied widely, devoicing was found to be less likely in carefully articulated speech or when pronouncing isolated phrases, and participants were not consistently aware of this phenomenon. Therefore, in this study, I have limited my discussion of phonological features to vowel lengthening in monosyllabic words – one of the most distinctive features of Kansai dialects as a whole.

As mentioned above, the vowel lengthening in monosyllabic nouns is a dialect feature observable without exception across the lexicon. However, when examined by pitch accent class, some variation can be observed. In particular, as noted by Okumura Mitsuo 奥村三雄,¹⁰ words with falling-pitch accents (Class II) appear more likely to be pronounced short than words with rising-pitch accents (Class III). That is, in family conversation, the dialect leveling (i.e., the sup-

7 Okumura, Mitsuo (奥村三雄). 1962. Kyōto-fu hōgen (京都府方言) [The dialect of Kyoto Prefecture]. In Umegaki, Minoru (榎垣実) (ed.), *Kinki hōgen no sōgō-teki kenkyū* (近畿方言の総合的研究) [Comprehensive research on Kinki dialects], 253–300. Sanseidō (三省堂).

8 Elementary schools surveyed: public - Shinmei 紫明, Motomachi 元町, Shichiku 紫竹, Kyōto Kyōiku Daigaku Fuzoku 京都教育大学附属 (all Kita Ward); private - Notre Dame (Sakyō Ward).

9 NHK (Nihon Hōsō Kyōkai) (ed.). 1966. *Nihongo hatsuon akusento jiten* (日本語発音アクセント辞典) [Pronunciation and pitch accent dictionary of Japanese]. Nihon Hōsō Shuppankai (日本放送出版協会).

10 Okumura, Mitsuo (奥村三雄). 1962. *Kinki shohōgen no akusento* (近畿諸方言のアクセント) [Pitch accent patterns of various Kinki dialects]. In Umegaki, Minoru (榎垣実) (ed.), *Kinki hōgen no sōgō-teki kenkyū* (近畿方言の総合的研究), 61–90. Sanseidō (三省堂).

pression of lengthening) of the former is no more than a little over 20%, whereas for the latter, the rate is nearly twice as high. Because awareness of standard Japanese is not significantly different between these two types, this suggests that the phenomenon may be due purely to pitch accent-related factors.

Status of Vowel Shortening in One-Mora Words (Dialect Leveling) (unit: percentage)

	Context	10s	20s	30s	40s	50s	60s	70+	Special
Hi 日 ‘day’/‘sun’ <i>hii+ga</i> (HL(L)) → <i>hi+ga</i> (L(H))	Awareness of Standard Japanese	80	70	70	40	25	20	20	15
	Public Conversation	45	60	60	25	20	10	0	90
	Family Conversation	40	35	33	20	18	10	0	54
Hi 火 ‘fire’ <i>hii+ga</i> (LH(H)) → <i>hi+ga</i> (H(L))	Awareness of Standard Japanese	70	70	70	38	20	15	15	94
	Public Conversation	35	45	50	20	10	10	0	92
	Family Conversation	25	21	20	10	10	10	0	50
Ka 蚊 ‘mosquito’ <i>kaa+ga</i> (HH(H)) → <i>ka+ga</i> (L(H))	Awareness of Standard Japanese	70	70	65	35	20	15	15	94
	Public Conversation	35	45	45	15	10	10	0	90
	Family Conversation	20	20	20	10	5	5	0	52

The above chart includes only the phenomenon of dialect leveling, that is, vowel shortening. There are a number of anomalies. To take Class II nouns as an example: while it is true that vowel lengthening declines as age decreases in dialect speech, there are numerous cases – especially in public conversation contexts – in which the word is phonologically standard Japanese but takes the pitch accent (H(L)), which is the exact opposite of the standard form (L(H)). These contradictory forms likely represent transitional stages in the process of dialect leveling, as previously discussed. Accordingly, the figures here should not be regarded as dialect leveling rates in a strict sense. The “special group”, however, can largely be treated as an exception: only 3 of 45 speakers exhibited this contradictory pattern, and there was little variation by vocabulary item overall. When considered by age group, again the 30s marks a divide. However, unlike in the case of pitch accent, the overall rate of dialect leveling is much higher, and the divide in public conversation is somewhat more gradual.

With regard to the latter, as will be discussed below when covering vocabulary, patterns unique to the dialect tend to be strongly recognized as dialect, and for age groups with high awareness of dialect leveling, such forms may be more likely to undergo leveling quickly. As a result, percentages for public conversation are overall closer to those for the level of standard Japanese awareness when compared to the findings for pitch accent. The emergence of a divide

in the 30s can be explained by the fact that this generation, more than those younger or older, is particularly conscious of dialect leveling. To offer more detailed numbers: among those in their 30s, 7 out of 25 speakers in public conversation and 2 out of 13 in private conversation exhibited the contradictory pattern in which the phonological form was made to match standard Japanese while the pitch accent remained dialectal. In contrast, among those in their teens, only 1 out of 9 in public contexts and 1 out of 8 in family contexts showed this pattern. This suggests that people in their 30s, in their conscious effort to use standard Japanese, are doing so without completely grasping it. This tendency is further corroborated by the table above. While the rate of dialect leveling in family conversation is highest among people between the ages of 10 and 19 and decreases with age, the peak for dialect leveling in public conversation occurs with people in their 30s – clearly indicating that speakers in this age group exhibit a dual linguistic structure, using different language at home and in public. This may be due in part to their greater frequency of contact with non-dialect speakers (i.e., outsiders) relative to other age groups. The relatively low contradictory pattern rate in the teens may be due to their limited exposure to such interactions.

With respect to this vowel lengthening phenomenon, it is worth noting that more than 50% of participants recognized the form as a monomoraic word when instructed to pronounce it “carefully”, whereas in more casual or careless pronunciation, most speakers exhibited lengthening. From this perspective, it seems clear that awareness of standard Japanese is fairly strong.

Grammar

In terms of usage, four constructions stand out in great contrast to standard Japanese:

- (1) The use of *u-onbin* in the adverbial form (*renyōkei* 連用形) of quadrigrade (*yodan* 四段) verbs with stems ending in *o ~ w* (*koota* 買ウタ ‘bought’; *oota* 会ウタ ‘met’)
- (2) The use of *ya* ヤ in place of the standard copula *da* ダ for assertions (*fune ya* 舟ヤ ‘it’s a boat’; *sizuka ya* 静カヤ ‘it’s quiet’)
- (3) The use of *-ya* ヤ as a command form in place of the standard imperative (*tabe-ya* 食べヤ ‘eat!’; *iki-ya* 行キヤ ‘go!’)
- (4) The use of *-N* ン to express negation in place of standard *-nai* ナイ (*siran* 知ラン ‘I dunno’; *akan* アカン ‘no good’)

While these forms vary in prevalence, they all clearly stand in contrast with standard Japanese.

I have compared and illustrated (1), (2), and (4) in tables. The imperative form (3) was excluded due to a lack of sufficient data caused by survey work oversight.

In (1), while there is no dialect leveling among participants aged 50 and above, over 80% of those in their teens showed evidence of it. Excluding *tou* 問ウ ‘to ask’, which shows variability even in standard Japanese, the same trend was found for other verbs in the group – *yoota* 酔ウタ ‘got drunk’, *kuuta* 食ウタ ‘ate’, *suuta* 吸ウタ ‘smoked, sucked’, *nuuta* 縫ウタ ‘sewed’, *yuuta* 言ウタ ‘said’, *koota* 買ウタ ‘bought’, *oota* 会ウタ ‘met’ – with very similar results. If we are to identify any distinction among these, it may be that verbs with relatively lower frequency of use among older speakers (e.g., *nuu*, *suu*, *yoo*) exhibit lower levels of dialect leveling. This suggests that lexical items with higher usage frequency are more likely to undergo leveling. Interestingly, for

the item *koota*, the standard Japanese form, that is, *katta*, is completely absent from the public conversation of older participants. This may be due to a perceived risk of confusion with the dialectal *katta* 借ッタ ‘borrowed’.

Status of Usage Standardization (unit: percent)

	Context	10s	20s	30s	40s	50s	60s	70+	Special
Use of <i>u-onbin</i> (<i>yuuta</i> 言ウタ, LHH, ‘said’)	Awareness of Standard Japanese	100	100	100	80	70	25	15	100
	Public Conversation	90	95	93	65	30	0	0	93
	Family Conversation	85	64	40	20	0	0	0	76
Assertion (<i>sizuka ya</i> 静カヤ, LLLH, ‘it’s quiet’)	Awareness of Standard Japanese	100	100	88	80	53	25	10	100
	Public Conversation	80	68	65	20	5	0	0	53
	Family Conversation	80	63	58	20	13	5	0	56
Negation (<i>siran</i> 知ラン ‘I dunno’)	Awareness of Standard Japanese	80	76	75	30	15	10	10	95
	Public Conversation	45	48	45	20	10	10	0	65
	Family Conversation	40	38	20	16	3	0	0	46

Examining the data in terms of verbal suffixes reveals some differences between *yuute* 言ウテ and *yuuta* 言ウタ: the latter appears more frequently and exhibits greater dialect leveling, particularly in public and family contexts. Although the age-based divide is not as stark as with accent or phonology, a generational divide is still evident, again centered in the 30s. While there is no pronounced gap in terms of the level of awareness of standard Japanese, the contrast in both public and family speech is particularly marked. That is, although those over 40 recognize the standard forms, they rarely use them in either public or private contexts. A simple questionnaire was administered on this.¹¹ (Participants in their 30s and 40s, yes/no answers.)

Reasons for Not Using Standard Japanese Language (105 respondents)

Reason	30s	40s
Because I don’t know the standard Japanese	70%	40%
Lack of familiarity (dialect feels easier to communicate with)	40%	70%
Awkward	25%	80%
Lack of confidence (difficult to use for some reason)	30%	80%
Other (e.g., feels unnatural, doesn’t fit)	10%	15%

¹¹ December 1969 oral questionnaire, at Mitsubishi Heavy Industries (Kyoto plant), Shimadzu Corporation, Sanjō Han’eikai (三条繁栄会), etc. Due to time constraints and other factors, the sample may have included speakers whose profiles were not ideal for the study.

The results suggest that a special awareness of standard Japanese is playing a large role. For example, some participants noted that using expressions like *soo da* そうだ ('that's right') as a declarative gave off a cold or aloof impression, or that they personally felt embarrassed saying it. Thus, people in their 40s appear to experience a much stronger psychological resistance to standard Japanese than those in their 30s. Notably, participants who cited subjective reasons like "it feels awkward" or "it's difficult to use for some reason" were nearly three times more common in their 40s than in their 30s. This may also help explain the generational divide in the use of declarative form *ya* and negative form *-N*. In (2), the declarative form *ya* also shows a similar degree of dialect leveling among younger generations. However, the percentage is surprisingly high among older people as well. This may be because (1) is more phonological while this usage is lexical.

The contrast in (4), between *-nai* and *-N* for negation, also reflects internal variation within standard Japanese itself: *-N* is often used to express stronger or more assertive forms of negation. As a result, speakers may have more difficulty identifying this as a dialectal form than (1) and (2). Compared to those constructions, awareness of the distinction is about 20% lower overall, and in family conversation, the rate of dialect leveling is roughly half. The 84% figure for the "special group" also reflects this. However, in the Kyoto dialect, *-N* rarely appears alone. It is generally used in forms like *-heN* へン or *-hiN* ヒン, which – as is the case with standard Japanese – are clearly different in meaning than *-N*. For the purpose of this study, however, all were grouped together under the category of *-N*. In any case, among the various aspects of usage examined here, this negation appears to be the slowest to undergo dialect leveling, likely because the form exists in both dialect and standard Japanese (speakers are not conscious of the existence of a corresponding standard Japanese construction). This makes it a particularly noteworthy case.

The generational divide appears to follow the same pattern as previously described.

Vocabulary

Vocabulary presents a wide range of variation, and because the number of relevant words is high, selecting representative examples proved to be difficult. To do so, I referred to Umegaki Minoru's 榎垣実 *Kyō kotoba* 京言葉 'Kyoto Speech' (Kōtō Shoin 高桐書院, 1946) and selected fifty words from the dialectal expressions listed there. To avoid including unusual words, I restricted the selection to those still actively used by a 72-year-old participant. Where possible, I prioritized items that overlapped with entries in NHK's *Zenkoku hōgen shiryō* 全国方言資料 'Countrywide dialect materials' (NHK, 1959–1972), and otherwise selected as I wished while maintaining a balanced distribution across parts of speech. I was able to broadly group dialect leveling by vocabulary item into three patterns. For convenience, I classified these into groups, with the following sets of vocabulary belonging to Group 1. (The standard Japanese word and an English translation, or an explanation, appears in parentheses.)

(1) “Akai-type”

akai アカイ (*akarui* 明るい, ‘bright’), *sabui* サブイ (*samui* 寒い, ‘cold’), *kayasu* カヤス (*kaesu* 返す, ‘to return’), *neburu* ネブル (*togu* 砥ぐ, ‘to polish’), *teQtau* テツタウ (*tetudau* 手伝う, ‘to help’), *dekeru* デケル (*dekiru* 出来る, ‘to be able to’), *inu* イヌ (*kaeru* 帰る, ‘to go home’), *iteru* イテル (*kooru* 氷る, ‘to freeze’), *naosu* ナオス (*katazukeru* 片付ける, ‘to put away’), *yaQsu* ヤツス (*mekasu* めかす, ‘to dress up’), *hoNma ni* ホンマニ (*jitu ni* 実に, ‘truly’), *tanto* タント (*takusan* 沢山, ‘a lot’), *erai* エライ (*hijō ni* 非常に, ‘very’), *tiQkoi* チッコイ (*tiisai* 小さい, ‘small’), *omoroi* オモロイ (*omoshiroi* 面白い, ‘interesting’), *gotui* ゴツイ (*ookii* 大きい, ‘big’), *susudo* ススドイ (*surudo* 鋭い, ‘sharp’), *gotekusa* ゴテクサ (expression used when scolding, etc.), *takimon* タキモン (*takimono* 焚き物, ‘firewood’), *tyoozu* チョーズ (*temizu* 手水, ‘water for hand and face washing’), *tenogoi* テノゴイ (*tenugui* 手拭い, ‘hand towel’), *bubu* ブブ (*otya* お茶, ‘tea’)

Status of Lexical Standardization (unit: percent)

Lexical Item	Category	10s	20s	30s	40s	50s	60s	70+	Special
Akai-type	Awareness of Standard Japanese	100	100	100	95	90	90	85	100
	Public Conversation	100	100	100	95	87	85	70	100
	Family Conversation	100	100	90	50	15	0	0	100
Gomoku-type	Awareness of Standard Japanese	100	100	100	100	95	90	90	100
	Public Conversation	100	100	100	85	83	65	45	100
	Family Conversation	90	90	90	60	50	30	0	100
Nanbo-type	Awareness of Standard Japanese	100	100	97	83	83	80	75	100
	Public Conversation	65	65	53	30	15	5	5	95
	Family Conversation	60	60	48	20	5	0	5	75

The common feature of these items is that many belong to the Kyoto dialect narrowly defined. That is, these words are clearly and unambiguously recognized as dialectal. Unlike the Group 2 “nanbo-type” words (discussed below), in which speakers often fail to recognize the term as dialect and remain unaware of its standard Japanese counterpart, the “akai-type” words all have clear equivalents in standard Japanese and are easily identified as dialect. For this reason, they undergo leveling more readily. Even among speakers over 60 who showed no leveling in family conversation, 85% used the standard form in public conversation. Consequently, most people in their 30s and younger do not use these words, while speakers over 50, who show little interest in dialect leveling, continue to use them without any thought. In the earlier chart, standard Japanese awareness falls below 100% for those aged 40 and above, but this does not mean they are unfamiliar with *akarui*. Rather, it shows the share of respondents who do not recognize that *akai* can correspond to *akarui* when the latter is used in a sense different than the standard ‘bright’ – such as in the phrase *akarui katei* 明ルイ家庭 ‘a cheerful household’. It is particularly noteworthy that while family conversation shows a roughly 50% drop in leveling between the 30s and 40s, and complete absence of leveling in the 60s, public conversation still exhibits a 70%

leveling rate among those over 70. This speaks to the distinctiveness of this group. Even among speakers who are otherwise highly conservative in their use of dialect, there appears to be a strong tendency to prioritize standard Japanese in vocabulary.

(2) “Gomoku-type”

subomu スボム (*sibomu* 萎む, ‘to wilt’), *kisanzina* キサンジナ (*kaikatu na* 快活な, ‘cheerful’), *toroi* トロイ (*nibui* 鈍い, ‘dull’), *kenarii* ケナリイ (*urayamasii* 羨ましい, ‘enviable’), *yotogi* 通夜 (*otuya ~ otuuya* お通夜 ‘funerary wake’), *nema* ネマ (*sinsitu* 寢室, ‘bedroom’), *nari* ナリ (*teisai* 体裁, ‘appearance’)

The status of dialect leveling for these words does not differ significantly from that of the “*akai*-type” words. However, notably, in family conversation, while leveling is extremely limited among older speakers for the *akai* group, about 40% of speakers in their 70s use the standard Japanese equivalent for this group. In short, across generations, the use of standard Japanese for these words is somewhat high on average. Take *gomoku* (garbage) as an example. Its ability to form new compounds reveals how far this dialect form has declined. While the word itself and the compound *gomoku-bako* ゴモク箱 (‘garbage bin’) might still be used, one won’t find many, or perhaps any, instances of *gomoku* instead of *gomi* in expressions such as *gomi-sha* ゴミ車 ‘garbage truck’, *gomi-toriki* ゴミ取器 ‘trash picker’, and *gomi-tame* ゴミ溜め ‘garbage heap’. The word is becoming obsolete. The fact that it is homophonous with *gomoku-zusi* 五目寿司 ‘mixed sushi’ may have also accelerated this decline. Overall, the words in this group – such as *kisanzi* and *kenarii* (only preserved in forms like *kenarigarū* ケナリガル) – can be considered archaisms. They have already begun to fossilize even as dialectal forms. Consequently, there is little generational variation in their leveling patterns and there are no notable issues needing examination.

(3) “Nanbo-type”

ototui オトツイ (*ototoi* 一昨日, ‘the day before yesterday’), *tukuri* ツクリ (*sasimi* 刺身, ‘sliced raw fish’), *tokake* トカケ (*tokage* 蜥蜴, ‘lizard’), *ban* バン (*yoru* 夜, ‘night’), *sendaku* センダク (*sentaku* 洗濯, ‘laundry’), *borokuso* ボロクソ (*mutyakutya* 無茶苦茶, ‘utter nonsense’), *tokoton* トコトン (*saigo made* 最後まで, ‘to the end’), *komame* コマメ (‘agile’), *mazaru* マザル (*maziru* 雑る, ‘to mix’), *hokasu* ホカス (*suteru* 捨てる, ‘to throw away’), *hamaru* ハマル (*otikomu* 落ち込む, ‘to fall into’), *goneru* ゴネル (‘to complain’), *maseru* マセル (*otonabiru* 大人びる, ‘to act grown up’), *sibui* シブイ (*shiwai* 吝い, ‘stingy’), *sewasinai* セワシナイ (*otitukanai* 落ち着かない, ‘restless’)

These terms are not specific to the narrowly defined Kyoto dialect but are better understood as part of the broader Kinki dialect. Many are close to standard Japanese – or, in some cases (e.g., *gametui*, *goneru*), have already been incorporated into it. As a result, they are less likely to be recognized as dialectal, and dialect leveling has not proceeded as noticeably in this group. This is confirmed by data from the “special group”, where the *nanbo*-type items showed the lowest rates of dialect leveling compared to the other types. In public conversation, the leveling rates for the *akai*- and *gomoku*-type items were close to the levels of standard language awareness, implying conscious use of the standard form. In contrast, *nanbo*-type terms are often used without thought in public contexts, likely because speakers do not perceive them as dialectal – hence the lower leveling rate. When examined by individual word, items such as *ototui*,

tokake, and *seNdaku*, which exhibit vowel alternation or voicing contrasts, showed especially low levels of leveling. Some speakers failed to notice that their pronunciation differed from the standard Japanese form at all.

In summary, the key point across vocabulary is that awareness of standard Japanese is over 90% across all age groups. This is a unique phenomenon, unlike the other aspects that have been studied. As the influence of vocabulary operates through both hearing and sight, speakers apprehend vocabulary from standard Japanese contrastively and encounter many occasions to reflect on it in ways different from pitch accent and phonological features, which rely solely on speech, something that can only be grasped spatially.

3

My findings can be summarized as follows.

- (1) Order of susceptibility to standardization: The linguistic features most readily leveled toward standard Japanese are lexicon – especially colloquial or slang-like items – followed by grammar, phonology, and finally pitch accent.
- (2) Generational divide: Although younger speakers predictably show more leveling than older speakers, the sharp break occurs almost without exception in people in their 30s. Point 1 confirms findings already advanced by scholars¹² and which do not need to be explained again.

Regarding point 2, the decisive factor seems to be that speakers in their 20s and 30s have a dual linguistic structure. They consciously differentiate between the language used in family conversation and that used in public conversation, and therefore a gap opens between them and the more linguistically consistent 40s group. Within this age group a striking mismatch emerges: despite a significant gulf between their level of awareness of standard Japanese and the actual degree of leveling visible in family speech, these speakers nonetheless make vigorous efforts to employ standard forms. Hence one encounters the odd language noted above – Kyoto phonology or vocabulary bearing a standard pitch accent, or the reverse. Among speakers aged 40 and above, such forced, unstable forms all but disappear; where leveling occurs, it is internally consistent. One plausible explanation for this generational fault line lies in standard-language education. The speakers who produce forced, unstable forms are precisely those whose formative linguistic years fell in the post-war period. The “Standard language education” of that era¹³ concentrated almost exclusively on vocabulary and left accent and phonology untouched, just teaching students to avoid using regional dialect words. Conversely, cohorts whose schooling

12 Shibata, Takeshi (柴田武). 1955. *Hōgen kara kyōtsūgo e* (方言から共通語へ) [From dialect to Standard Japanese]. *Gengo seikatsu* (言語生活) 41. 13–22; Kokuritsu Kokugo Kenkyūjo (国立国語研究所) (ed.). 1951. *Kokuritsu kokugo kenkyūjo hōkoku* (国立国語研究所報告) 2 [National Institute of Japanese Language and Linguistics Report No. 2]. Shūei Shuppan (秀英出版); Kokuritsu Kokugo Kenkyūjo (国立国語研究所) (ed.). 1953. *Kokuritsu kokugo kenkyūjo hōkoku* (国立国語研究所報告) 5 [National Institute of Japanese Language and Linguistics Report No. 5]. Shūei Shuppan (秀英出版); Okumura, Mitsuo (奥村三雄). 1961. *Hōgen no jittai to kyōtsūgoka no mondai-ten* (方言の実態と共通語化の問題点) [Issues regarding the actual state of dialects and standardization]. In Endō, Yoshimoto (遠藤嘉基) & Hirayama, Teruo (平山輝男) & Ōkubo, Tadatōshi (大久保忠利) & Shibata, Takeshi (柴田武) (eds.), *Hōgengaku kōza* (方言学講座) [Studies in dialectology], vol. 3, 111–150. Tōkyōdō (東京堂).

13 Jōkō, Kan'ichi (上甲幹一). 1953. *Hyōjungo no gakushū shidōhō* (標準語の学習指導法) [Methods for teaching Standard Japanese]. Tōyōkan Shuppansha (東洋館出版社).

coincided with the audiovisual education boom from the mid-1950s onward show little duality. As already shown in the discussion of velar nasal *g*, education and dialect are closely linked.

List of Surveyed Persons in their 30s by Age

Age	No. of Persons
30	1
31	3
32	5
33	4
34	5
35	8
36	5
37	5
38	5
39	4
Total	40

Overall Averages (Dialect Leveling)

	30s	40s
Awareness of Standard Japanese	69.4%	53.6%
Public Conversation	57.3%	31.4%
Family Conversation	34.6%	20.2%

A more fine-grained age breakdown produces the results below. The table averages the thirteen items reported in this paper for participants in their 30s and 40s. Although individual variation exists, in terms of averages people aged 36.5 and younger fall below the overall average. The true break occurs between the ages of 36 and 37, in accordance with the hypothesis just advanced. The questionnaire on reasons for avoiding standard Japanese sheds further light: expressions such as *soo da* strike many forty-somethings as “awkward” or “difficult to use for some reason” whereas those in their 30s, who more often say they cannot use such expressions because of lack of knowledge, imply that they would adopt those expressions once learned. In short, people in their 30s actively seek to use standard Japanese (albeit resulting in forced, unstable forms), while those in their 40s are markedly more conservative. Evidently, a dialect-based psychological complex vis-à-vis Tokyo speech manifests most strongly – and behaviorally – in the 20s to mid-30s, ages that are probably the most engaged with the outside world.

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